position. Castro also managed to turn the communist old guard into scapegoats at a time when popular support for his regime was declining and discontent caused by the worsening economic situation was on the rise.[14]

The brewing Cuban crisis was brought urgently home to the Kremlin when Escalante came to Moscow to tell his side of the story. Chinese influences were on the rise in Havana, he claimed: he had tried to curtail them, only to lose his position. Escalante submitted his report to the Central Committee on April 3, 1962. Prospects looked grim, and Khrushchev had to act. Eight days after Escalante filed his report, the Central Committee's mouthpiece, the newspaper *Pravda*, published a long article on the situation in the Cuban leadership. To Escalante's disappointment and, probably, shock, the Central Committee decided to renounce him and back his nemesis, Fidel Castro, whose actions Escalante had tried to explain as a result of growing Chinese influence. *Pravda* stressed the need for unity against imperialist aggression.[15]

Forced to choose between the old communist Escalante and the brand-new Marxist Castro, Khrushchev had decided to back the latter, in whose leadership he saw the best guarantee of keeping Cuba in the Soviet camp. The KGB informed him that the Chinese threat in Havana was being exaggerated, and he believed that the threat of American invasion was real. On March 12, Aleksei Adzhubei, the editor of *Izvestiia* and Khrushchev's son-in-law, sent the Central Committee a report on his conversations with President Kennedy earlier that year. Among other things, they had discussed Cuba. "From a psychological point of view, it is very hard for the American people to agree with what is going on in Cuba," Kennedy told Adzhubei. "After all, it is only 90 miles from our coast. It is very hard." He compared favorably the decisive measures taken by the USSR in Hungary in 1956 with the CIA's inability to handle Cuba. The impression conveyed by the memo was that Kennedy had not given up on Cuba, and that military intervention was coming.[16]

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